THE LAWS OF SOFTWARE TEAMS

The Peter principle

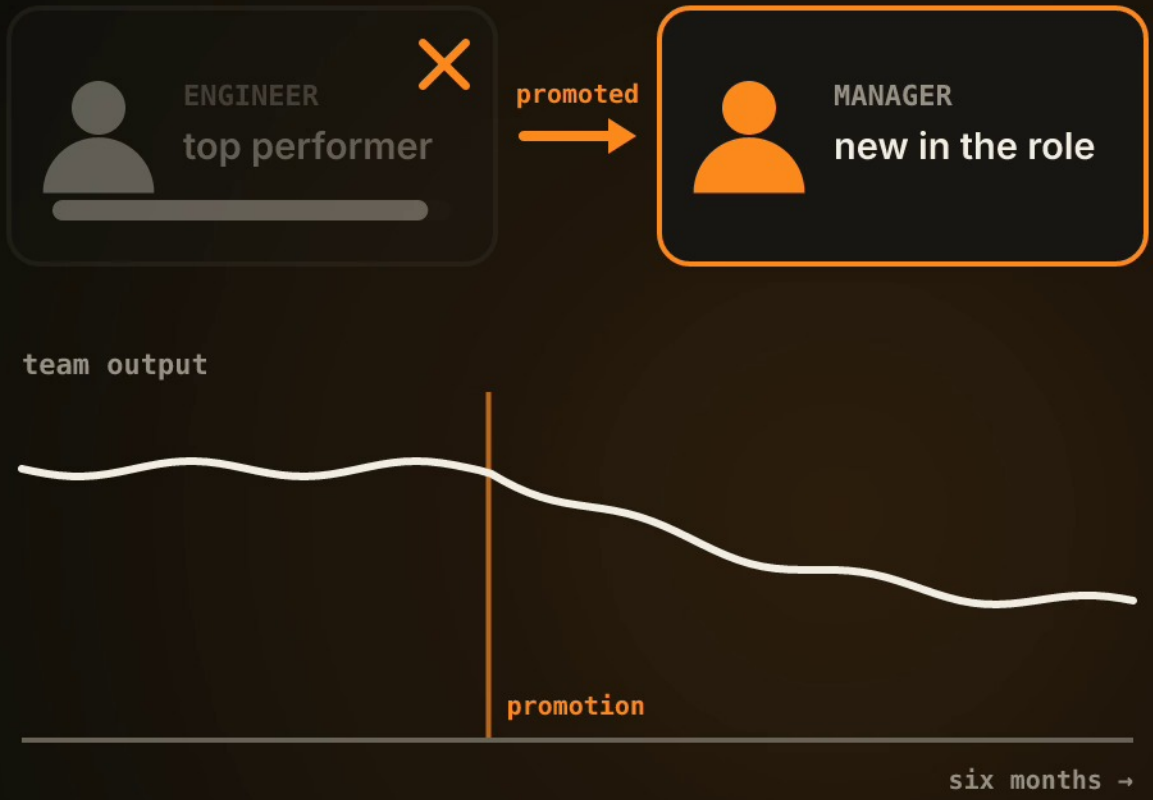
In a hierarchy, people rise to their level of incompetence

swipe →

Ivan Rykov

01 THE HOOK

Best engineer, new manager

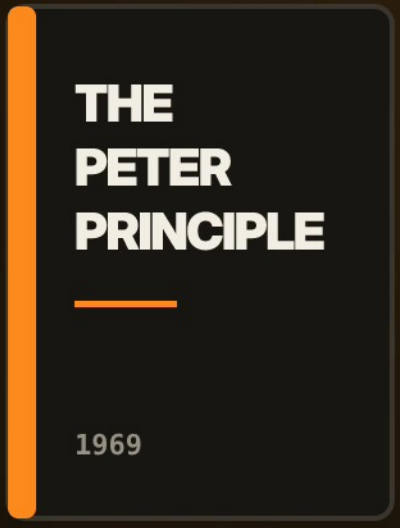


A slower team, and one engineer fewer

This has a name

illustration

“In a hierarchy, every employee tends to rise to his level of incompetence”



Laurence J. Peter
& Raymond Hull

William Morrow, 1969

written as satire
and read as truth

Promoted for the job they already do



Each promotion rewards the last job

illustration

Satire, but the data agrees

53,035 sales workers

214 firms · 2005-2011



1 dot ≈ 500 workers

1,531 promoted to manager

BENSON, LI & SHUE · 2019

Quarterly Journal of Economics

Top sellers made weaker bosses

DOUBLE YOUR SALES

+14.3%

chance of promotion



DOUBLE THE NEW MANAGER'S OLD SALES

−7.5%

sales per team member



A BETTER SIGNAL

Shared sales

with colleagues before the promotion

relative changes · an association, not proof · Benson, Li & Shue, 2019

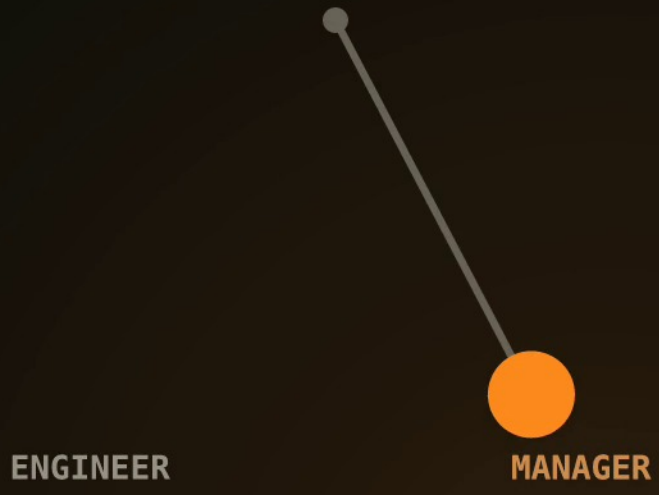
Two ladders, not one

TECHNICAL	MANAGEMENT
Principal	Director
Staff	Manager
Senior	Team lead
Engineer	Engineer

Try first: tech lead · lead one project

illustration · level names vary by company

Make the way back safe



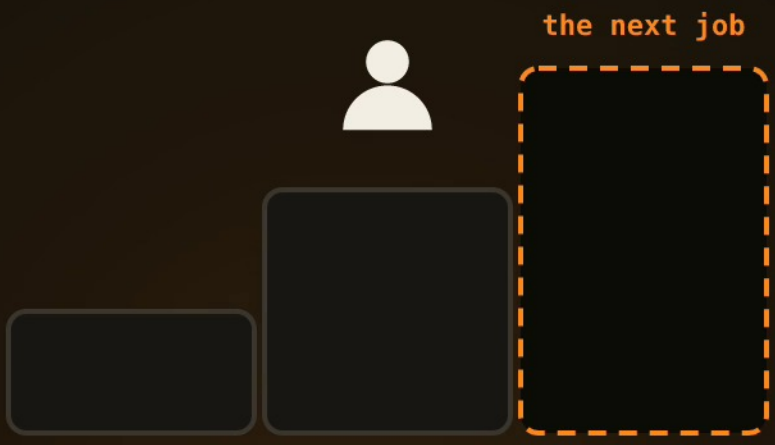
CHARITY MAJORS · THE ENGINEER/MANAGER PENDULUM · 2017

> “Management is not a promotion, management is a change of profession”

charity.wtf, 11 May 2017

Going back is not a failure

Promote for the next job



Not for the last one

TAKEAWAY

Promote for the next job

Not for the last one

Sources: Peter and Hull, 1969 · Benson, Li and Shue, 2019 · Charity Majors, 2017

next: Gilb's law